



Alabaster

△ Specimen of rough gypsum alabaster

Fine-grained masses of gypsum are known as alabaster. The origin of the word is probably Middle English, but is ultimately derived from the Greek *alabastos*, a term referring to a vase made of alabaster. Alabaster vessels called *a-labaste* were widely used by worshippers of the goddess Bast in ancient Egypt, which may also reflect the origin of the name. Alabaster has been carved into ornaments, containers, and even utensils, for thousands of years, and it is sometimes made to look more like marble by heat-treating it to reduce translucency.

Specification

Chemical name Calcium sulphate hydrate | **Formula** $\text{CaSO}_4 \cdot 2\text{H}_2\text{O}$ | **Colours** Colourless, white, yellow, light brown | **Structure** Monoclinic | **Hardness** 2 | **SG** 2.3 | **RI** 1.52–1.53 | **Lustre** Subvitreous to pearly | **Streak** White | **Locations** Egypt, Italy



Italian alabaster | **Rough** | While Italian marble is famous worldwide, the country's fine alabaster is less well known. These pieces of Italian rough have an almost wax-like appearance.



Waxy surface texture
Colour variations



Calcite alabaster jar | **Carved** | Calcite alabaster was widely used in ancient Egypt (see box). This canopic jar of Psamtikpadineith is from the 26th Dynasty, c.600 BCE.

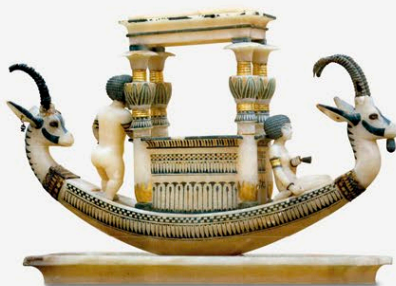


Alabaster bust | **Carved** | This Italian gilt alabaster bust dates back to around 1900, and is modelled in the style of a Renaissance maiden.

Calcite alabaster

Alabaster in Tutankhamun's tomb

Even today, ancient items produced from banded calcite are still referred to as being made from "calcite alabaster". A famous ancient source of this was Hattsub, Egypt, and it is likely that some of the alabaster objects in Tutankhamun's tomb were carved in stone from this source, particularly the vases and canopic jars that held his internal organs. It was also used to make buildings, bowls, the inlaid eyes of statues, and more.



Egyptian carving An elaborately decorated ancient Egyptian casket carved from calcite alabaster



Ancient vase | **Carved** | This early vase was carved from alabaster in the ancient city of Ur (now in Iraq) some time in the 2nd millennium BCE.



Alabaster bust | **Carved** | This bust in Italian alabaster by the 18th-century artist Giovanni Battista Cipriani shows the delicate tones and fine detail possible in alabaster carvings.